

A CLASSY COLLAB Raja Kumari performing with Ali Sethi at the Coachella festival

terviews involved being told that she would be given a larger budget for her video if she didn't wear a bindi.

Widely regarded as one of the most successful rappers in India, and the country's foremost female MC, Kumari's string of achievements include headlining the Bacardi NH7 Weekender festival in Pune, judging the first season of reality TV hip-hop competition series *MTV Hustle*, and a cameo in the film *Gully Boy*, all of which she did in 2019. Earlier this year, she played the Walkers & Co. tour, which marked American R&B singer John Legend's debut concerts in Mumbai and New Delhi.

But when she moved to Mumbai in 2017, she already had an impressive CV that boasted songwriter credits on a pair of 2014 releases—pop-punk band Fall Out Boy's US top 10 smash 'Centuries' and rapper Iggy Azalea's Grammy-nominated album *The New Classic*.

Kumari's success in India as a female artist rapping in English was notable in a scene where the most popular hip-hop acts are male stars rhyming in Hindi or a regional language. She believes she was able to break through for a number of reasons. "It was [a combination of the] timing [of hip-hop blowing up in India], luck, attitude and music," says Kumari. "I came with that all-American attitude, like I'll pull myself up [by] my bootstraps, anything is possible. I didn't know about the limitations that were societally supposed to be placed on me. So I would just walk through them."

While she's an established name in this country, where until recently she was spending the majority of the year, she's lesser known to the US audience outside of the diaspora. In a shot at global stardom, she decided to return to the US and visit India only for the festival season.

Kumari is now represented by international talent agency WME, through which she scored a slot at the inaugural edition of the Middle East leg of popular UK rap festival Wireless, which was held in Abu Dhabi in March. Just a couple of weeks ago, she joined Ali Sethi on stage at the Coachella festival to duet with him on 'Pasoori'. She's also working with Latium Entertainment, the company formed by Charles Chavez, best known as Cuban-American rapper Pitbull's former manager. "He was present during the Latin explosion," says Kumari. "So instead of me convincing American people constantly that India is about to break, it's like having a brown person that was there, on the team. I have to fight him so much less."

On Kumari's list of long-term goals are a number-one hit on the US charts and a Grammy win. For now, her immediate focus is her new album, the response to which she says she is equanimous about. "I would love for this to be the album that everybody discovered me through but I don't put a lot of pressure on my art anymore." ■

Amit Gurbaxani

home, says we can expect the collection to be out in the third quarter. Titled *Karam*, it's a concept album based around a doomed protagonist whose story is told through a series of interludes that link the 13 tracks. It will feature, among others, rappers HanuMankind, King, MC Stan, Raftaar, Raja Kumari and Seedhe Maut, and singer-songwriter Zaeden.

Karam will be a rare instance of acts belonging to different camps in desi hip-hop coming together outside of a festival. But KSHMR says the artists he invited readily agreed to join the project. "I never got the impression that somebody wouldn't be part of the album because somebody else is involved," he says. "Though there are a lot of beefs in Indian hip-hop, there's a lot of respect as well."

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KSHMR discovered our home-grown hip-hop scene after watching the 2019 Hindi film *Gully Boy*. The movie inspired the musician, who started out wanting to be a rapper before he switched to electronic music, to return to his hip-hop roots and collaborate with the country's hottest rap stars. "It blew my mind," he says. "It was like this new fire ignited in me."

He's previewed a few of *Karam*'s songs during recent live shows in India, at the Zomato Feeding India Concert in December 2022 and the Road To Ultra festival in April. The response, he says, has been "really, really good". Based on comments on his Instagram, some listeners are less pleased with the inclusion of popular Indian film hits, such as 'Doobey' from *Gehraiyaan* (2022) and 'Oo Antava' from *Pushpa: The Rise* (2021) in his sets. However, he doesn't plan to stop playing them.

"Some people say they've come to see a KSHMR show, [so] they don't want to hear the same tracks they always hear," he says. "It's fun for me though. To play a Bollywood track mixed with my own and see the crowd go crazy keeps [things] exciting. I'm going to keep doing it." ■

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